Alma Elape Berowa

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa: From Scholar of Psychology to Steward of a University System in Times of Crisis

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Introduction: A Life Shaped by Place and Purpose

Most conversations about Philippine higher education tend to circle back to Metro Manila, where the big budgets and the national policies get made.

But down in Mindanao, a different kind of leadership has been building quietly for decades, the kind that gets forged through endurance, cultural fluency, and the ability to hold things together when a crisis hits.

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa is a good example of exactly that. Her career at Mindanao State University (MSU) stretched more than four decades, starting as a young instructor in 1980 and eventually landing her the distinction of the longest-serving Vice President for Academic Affairs in the university system's history, a post she held from 2011 until her retirement in 2025.

Her story is tied closely to what MSU was built to do in the first place: bridge cultures, educate communities that history had often left behind, and offer a sense of stability in a region that has seen more than its share of conflict.

Her career is a reminder that academic leadership doesn't stay confined to classrooms and committee rooms. Sometimes it becomes something much closer to public service.

Early Life: Foundations of Excellence in Gigaquit

Dr. Berowa was born on September 16, 1960, in Gigaquit, Surigao del Norte, a town in the Caraga region.

Even as a child, she stood out academically: salutatorian in elementary school, valedictorian in high school.

Those are not small achievements for someone growing up in a provincial setting where opportunities were limited. They took real discipline, persistence, and a clear sense of direction from an early age.

Her move to Mindanao State University marked a turning point in her life. MSU had been established specifically to bring the country's diverse cultural communities together, and it became the institutional home where her intellectual and professional identity really took shape.

Education: The Making of a Social Psychologist

She entered MSU as a full scholar and completed her Bachelor of Arts in Psychology, graduating cum laude in 1980.

Her undergraduate training included a minor in sociology, which gave her an interdisciplinary lens early on: she never really saw human behavior as something isolated, but as something shaped by social structures, cultural practices, and lived experience.

From there, she pursued graduate studies in education, first at the University of the Philippines Diliman, before completing her Master of Arts in Education (major in Guidance and Counseling) at MSU.

That combination, psychology paired with education, reflected a dual commitment: understanding human behavior on one hand, and applying that understanding to real institutional and community problems on the other.

Her academic journey reached its peak with a Doctor of Philosophy in Psychology, major in Social Psychology, from Ateneo de Manila University between 1990 and 1996.

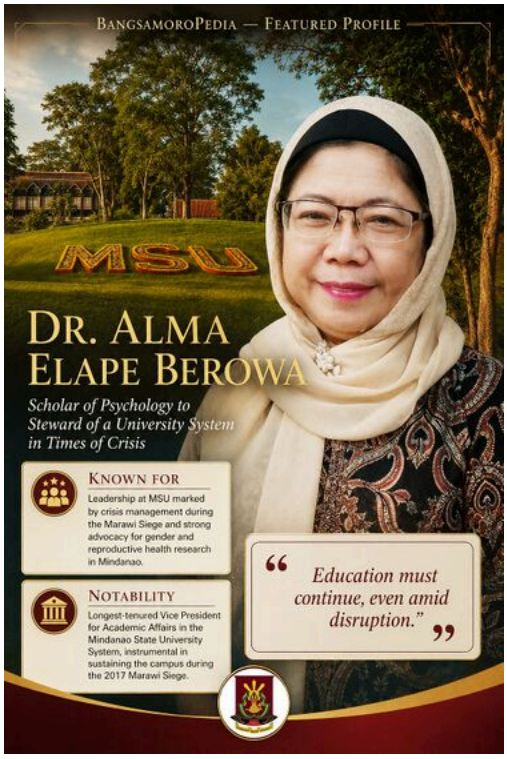
That period of advanced study deepened her interest in questions of identity, conflict, and social interaction, themes that would later sit right at the center of her research and leadership work in Mindanao.

Looking back, her education reads almost like a deliberate preparation: a scholar being shaped for work that would eventually intersect with some of the region's most pressing social issues.

Academic Career: Rising Through the Ranks

Dr. Berowa began her academic career in 1980 as an Instructor I in the Department of Psychology at MSU.

Over the next four decades, she moved steadily through the ranks: Full Professor VI by 2000, and University Professor by 2022.

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa

Born
September 16, 1960
Birthplace
Gigaquit, Surigao del Norte (Caraga Region)
Religion
Not specified in available sources
Home Address
038 4th Street, MSU Campus, Marawi City
Spouse
Pasayod P. Berowa (Retired HRMO III, PhilHealth BARMM: deceased)
Children
Ian Nasser Berowa, Ivan Yasser Berowa, Ivy Sarah Mae Berowa, Pasayod Berowa Jr., Ivar Shanollah Berowa
Academic Position
University Professor (Retired)
Position
Vice President for Academic Affairs, MSU System
Tenure

Her rise wasn't sudden. It was built year by year on teaching, research, and service, the kind of long tenure that lets a person really understand an institution's culture and its challenges from the inside.

She was shaped by the system, and in turn, she helped shape it: contributing to curriculum development, mentoring students and junior faculty, and taking part in academic governance. Her role expanded gradually from teacher to steward of the university's intellectual direction.

2011 to 2025
Notability
Longest-serving Vice President for Academic Affairs in the history of the Mindanao State University System, and a key figure in campus survival during the 2017 Marawi Siege
Known For
Institutional leadership at MSU, crisis response during the Marawi Siege, and advocacy for gender and reproductive health research in Mindanao
Pull Quote
"Education must continue, even amid disruption."

Leadership: From Department to System

Before she reached system-wide leadership, Dr. Berowa held a string of administrative posts within MSU Marawi: Department Chair of Psychology, Guidance Coordinator, College Secretary, Assistant Dean, and eventually Dean of the College of Social Sciences and Humanities.

Each of those roles added another layer to her understanding of how academic institutions actually run, from the department level all the way up to college-wide administration.

When she became Vice President for Academic Affairs in 2011, she brought all of that accumulated experience with her. Her tenure lasted until 2025, the longest in the history of the MSU System.

During those years, she oversaw the core of academic governance: curriculum development, faculty promotion, admissions, scholarship programs, and accreditation.

Her leadership style leaned toward continuity and system-building rather than quick fixes. She chaired several key bodies, including the University System Curriculum Committee, the Academic Promotion Panel, and the Quality Assurance Board, all central to keeping academic standards intact and improving.

That approach paid off in measurable ways: under her guidance, MSU achieved top national rankings in accredited programs, particularly in 2023 and 2024, a reflection of both administrative discipline and a genuine commitment to academic quality.

Crisis Leadership: The Marawi Siege

Her administrative record shows what she could build over time. What happened in 2017 showed what she could do under pressure.

When armed conflict broke out in Marawi City on May 23, 2017, the MSU campus suddenly found itself at the center of a humanitarian crisis. Many people fled for safety. Dr. Berowa stayed.

From the first day of the siege until the city's liberation that October, she remained on campus with a small group of university officials.

Her responsibilities during that period went far beyond academic administration. She helped organize the evacuation of vulnerable faculty and students, took part in distributing food and essential supplies to those still on campus and in the surrounding communities, and drew on her training as a psychologist to lead psychosocial interventions for people coping with trauma and displacement.

> One of the most symbolic moments of that period was the "Bakwit Graduation" held in Iligan City, which allowed displaced students to complete an important milestone in their lives even as their city remained under siege.

That moment captures something central to how she led: education has to continue, even when everything else is falling apart.

Her presence during the siege changed how people understood her role. She wasn't just an academic administrator anymore. She had become a crisis leader, a humanitarian worker, and for a community in turmoil, a source of stability.

Scholarship and Advocacy: Gender, Peace, and Society

Alongside her administrative work, Dr. Berowa stayed active in research and advocacy focused on reproductive health, gender dynamics, and the experiences of communities affected by conflict.

Her published work explored the reproductive health perspectives of Maranao youth, the experiences of women living through conflict, and the ethical challenges researchers face when studying marginalized communities. This wasn't research for its own sake: it connected academic inquiry directly to real-world concerns.

She was a founding member of the Al-Mujadilah Development Foundation, an organization focused on women's rights and development in Muslim communities, and she also worked with BIRTHDEV, which supports women and children affected by conflict and disaster.

Through these efforts, she managed to bridge a gap that a lot of academics never quite close: turning research into work that has a tangible impact beyond the pages of a journal.

Gender and Institutional Reform

As Chair of Gender and Development from 2015 to 2023, Dr. Berowa worked to integrate gender perspectives into university policies and programs.

She helped mainstream gender sensitivity in the curriculum and pushed awareness of issues like violence against women and reproductive health.

Her efforts lined up with national and international frameworks on gender equality, which helped position MSU as a genuinely responsive institution. She also took part in policy discussions at the national level through her involvement with the Commission on Higher Education and other bodies.

Global Engagement and Academic Exchange

Dr. Berowa's work reached beyond Mindanao and beyond the Philippines through conferences, research collaborations, and academic exchanges.

She took part in Erasmus exchange programs in Portugal and Türkiye, experiences that enriched the MSU System's internationalization efforts and gave her a chance to bring Mindanao's challenges to a wider audience.

Personal Life and Values

Behind the titles and the institutional achievements is a life shaped by personal commitments. She is a mother of five, several of whom have gone on to build their own careers in academia and public service.

Her role as a parent, and her experience as a widow, reflect a balance she's had to strike between personal resilience and public duty throughout her life.

Service, empathy, and a deep commitment to community: those values show up consistently in both her professional record and her personal life.

A Legacy of Continuity and Care

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa's career is really a case study in what academic leadership can look like when it's grounded in both intellectual rigor and genuine human concern.

Her work strengthened institutional systems, advanced scholarship, and kept education going during one of the most difficult periods in MSU's history.

Her legacy isn't just about the titles she held. It's about the impact she had on students, colleagues, and the wider community.

In a region often defined in the headlines by conflict and hardship, she showed that leadership rooted in knowledge, compassion, and resilience can produce change that actually lasts.

Further Reading

Mindanao State University (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/) — Official MSU Website

University of the Philippines Diliman (https://up.edu.ph) — Official UP Diliman Website

References

<references/>

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